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Teens are Patrons, Too: The Case for Restorative Justice Practices and Youth-Friendly Policies in Public Libraries

Public libraries in the United States are touted as pillars of intellectual freedom that provide patrons from all walks of life free access to information and resources. While many in the library profession strive for this lofty ideal, the unfortunate reality is that too many library patrons do not experience equity in access when they enter public library spaces. It should not be surprising that the systemic inequities in society also exist in libraries thanks to the internalized biases of library staff; however, it is disappointing. These conscious or unconscious biases exclude traditionally underserved patron groups from library spaces. Existing research reveals how standard library policies perpetuate harm against patrons experiencing homelessness and patrons of color. This research tends to focus on the impacts on adult library users. As a teen reference librarian and former secondary school teacher, I am interested in how teenage library users are affected by library policies created without their needs in mind. In my experience, youth of color are likelier to be the subjects of scrutiny and interference from library staff. Implementing youth-friendly patron codes of conduct and restorative justice practices in public libraries can reduce the over-policing of youth and teens of color, fostering a more inclusive and supportive environment that promotes trust and engagement.

Since the Progressive Era, public libraries have served as community hubs and intellectual sanctuaries (Mattson). Unfortunately, library services were uneven for marginalized groups, and Civil Rights activists had to fight to desegregate libraries (Wiegand and Wiegand). Our United Statesian legacy of systemic inequities continues to influence library operations today despite idealistic mission and vision statements. As Corina Bardoff states, “If the mission of the library is to meet the information needs of their community, the library’s policies should be considered in that light” (358). Bardoff’s writing criticizes restrictive policies that create unnecessary barriers for patrons experiencing homelessness, such as policies against strong body odor, sleeping in the library, or carrying too many personal belongings.

Similarly, Cass Balzer, Jarrett Dapier, and Emily Knox have written about the over-reliance on police officers and private security to handle patron behavior issues that do not pose a threat to library staff or other patrons. Because systemic racism is systemic, inviting police officers into the library to act as behavior enforcement creates a decidedly unsafe environment for patrons of color, even those who are not actively causing problems. Doing so may also make staff members who belong to marginalized groups feel uncomfortable or unsafe at work. By off-loading social-emotional interactions onto police officers or security personnel, libraries create unsafe environments for our most vulnerable patrons and perpetuate biased enforcement of patron codes of conduct.

Teenage patrons are particularly susceptible to unfair treatment because they have been trained since childhood to comply with adults in positions of authority, like teachers and librarians, and they are more likely than adults to be unaware of their rights in public spaces. As Amelia N. Gibson and her collaborators note:

> Systemic norms and cultural narratives about youth are not all created equally. Adults often expect Black, Native, and Latine/x youth in particular to demonstrate 'challenging behavior' … and are more likely to label age-appropriate and culturally appropriate information seeking and sharing behaviors as cause for discipline. Public and school libraries follow this trend. (Gibson et al. 1514)

These systemic biased cultural narratives manifest in library policies and patron codes of conduct, which do not consider the needs of all library patrons. As well-intentioned as policies and codes of conduct may be, their inherent problems create problematic library environments.

The problem with traditional patron codes of conduct is that they assume a certain degree of homogeneity among library patrons. Logically, of course, library staff know that libraries are for everyone. However, an assumption exists of shared cultural norms—expectations of how libraries "should" be based on outdated impressions that might never have been founded in reality. In this imagined public library, quiet, respectful patrons come in for independent study or to check out books. Young children come in for scheduled story times with their attentive and responsible caregivers, who whisk them away when they get too loud. Patrons and staff who come to libraries with such idyllic fantasies may find the bustling, diverse, and, yes, sometimes noisy reality of a public library somewhat jarring. In reality, public libraries serve as a community safe space, an after-school hangout, and unofficial childcare for caregivers who cannot pick their children up directly after their school dismissal times.

At best, problematic library policies fail to acknowledge patrons' diversity and unique needs. At worst, they prioritize the comfort of a narrow segment of library users by manufacturing ways to remove patrons who could introduce discomfort. Vaguely worded patron

codes of conduct leave it up to library staff to decide what is and is not appropriate behavior. Policies that prohibit "interfering with the use and enjoyment of the library by others" and "failure to comply with any request or demand of library staff" seem reasonable at first glance but can have negative impacts on patrons who are outside the assumed cultural norms ("Patron Code of Conduct"). Arbitrary enforcement targets patrons experiencing homelessness, patrons who are neurodiverse, patrons who are people of color, patrons who are immigrants, and patrons who are teenagers. Patrons at the intersections of these identities are even more adversely affected.

Rules are sometimes inconsistently applied based on staff biases, leading to distrust and disengagement (Gibson et al.). The adverse effects of inconsistent rule enforcement show up in situations in which a library staffer reminds a rowdy group of white teens to quiet down yet tells rowdy teens of color that they have to leave the library for the day. In library systems that use patron incident reporting systems, such "incidents" as these can lead to suspensions and bans from the library. A case study of tweens and teens of color in North Carolina revealed that "Black, Latine/x, and immigrant youths bear an especially high burden in these spaces and are far more likely than their white counterparts to be surveilled, arrested, harmed, or physically removed from libraries around the country," replicating broader societal inequities (Gibson and Hughes-Hassell 278). In Arizona, "staff at Pima County Public Library began to recognize that despite differences in youth and adult brain development, youth and adult behaviors were addressed indistinguishably in branch libraries; consequently, high-needs youth were disproportionately suspended" (Davey 29-30). Social interactions are crucial for teen development, yet libraries often discourage group behavior under the guise of maintaining order (Chelton).

Aside from the obvious issue of library policies leading to the exclusion of patrons from libraries, another problem exists—the disconnect between these policies and the American Library Association's "Library Bill of Rights." Article VII emphasizes that libraries have a professional obligation to provide equitable access to resources for all patrons, which includes minors. Furthermore, the ALA explains that minors and students "have a right to be free from any unreasonable intrusion into or surveillance of their lawful library use" ("Access"). In practical terms, this means that teenage library users should not have to worry about library staff listening in on their conversations to chastise them for using profanity or repeatedly telling them to be quiet in order to wield a "failure to comply" policy and kick the teens out of the library space. The ALA asserts that "the mission, goals, and objectives of libraries cannot authorize libraries and their governing bodies to assume, abrogate, or overrule the rights and responsibilities of parents and guardians" ("Access"). In other words, unless a teen patron's behavior is truly disruptive, harmful, or unlawful, it is up to parents and guardians—not library staff—to decide whether their teen's behavior is problematic. This is not to say that library staff have no recourse when managing teen behaviors. Rather, there are better ways to handle negative patron behaviors and teach young patrons the expectations for appropriate behavior in library settings. Infringing on their rights to access information, resources, and library services is unnecessary.

In her work on the information needs of patrons experiencing homelessness, Bardoff criticizes restrictive library policies and advocates for libraries to adopt a social justice perspective of patron services (358). A social justice lens requires decentering controlling tendencies and punitive measures in favor of centering patrons' needs and systems that treat patrons with dignity and respect. Educators concerned about the school-to-prison pipeline

realized years ago that punitive disciplinary practices were not achieving the desired outcomes for students.

> As commonly understood, school discipline seeks to stop misbehavior, teach prosocial behavior, and motivate healthier decision making in the misbehaving student. In practice, the means to these ends often take a punitive path that fosters a self-protective posture, a sense of powerlessness, and a negative attitude that can contribute to an ongoing cycle of harm. School suspensions and loss of privileges mirror a criminal justice system that looks and feels like retribution or payback. Although the misbehavior may be stifled in the immediate context, the possibility of long-term change is small. Further, an exclusive focus on the misbehaving student ignores the harm done to those affected by misbehavior. (Mullet 157)

In an effort to reduce harm and increase prosocial behaviors, schools and now libraries are incorporating restorative justice into their behavior management practices. Unlike "behavior management that relies on punishment, coercion, or exclusions," restorative justice practices emphasize accountability, community, and healing ("Restorative Conversations"). Restorative practices can make adults anxious because they are not "linear" or "scripted;" there are "no prioritized lists of consequences" to enforce when teens misbehave (Mullet 159). Instead of relying on punitive "if this, then that" codes of conduct, restorative practices depend on conversations framed in mutual respect and trust.

With the guidance of an adult in a position of authority—for our purposes, library staff—the misbehaving teen patron must "accept accountability for their actions, reflect on the impact they have on others, and, when needed, take steps to repair relationships and build new

skills" ("Restorative Conversations"). This restorative process aims to foster an environment of trust, equity, and inclusion while maintaining standards for behavior and interpersonal interactions. Staff may resist adopting this restorative approach because it requires more engagement with teen patrons and more nuanced judgment of individual situations than simply stating that a particular behavior is not allowed and telling teens to leave the library.

At the 2024 Public Library Association conference, panelists from Cincinnati and Hamilton County Public Library and Columbus Metropolitan Library in Ohio discussed their implementation of restorative practices for patrons under 18 years of age. It took over two years to gain acceptance and traction in all their branches. They stress that there is not a one-size-fits-all approach to restorative practices but suggest a framework that begins with educating patrons about library rules and having proactive informal conversations during patrons' library visits. They created a Restorative Practices Toolkit that includes simple worksheets for written reflections to help guide restorative conversations (Causey et al.). This process builds stronger relationships between library staff and young patrons, leading to "fewer incidents of negative behaviors requiring staff intervention and [creating] a welcoming environment for youth" (Braun). A welcoming library environment where library staff support and guide young patrons aligns more with the values espoused in the "Library Bill of Rights" and library mission statements.

Adopting restorative justice practices is one way to address the inequities teen patrons face in libraries. Another is to revisit problematic policies. As academic librarian Anastasia M. Collins points out, "Consider what it means to espouse a philosophy that holds young adults as a distinct and valuable group with their own needs and uses of the library, and then to create policies that implicitly preserve adult comfort or adult ideas of what the library should be used

for" (17-18). From a restorative justice perspective that aims to reduce harm, libraries must acknowledge that sometimes their policies are "a root cause of the harm done" which erase the "distinct needs" of patrons (Collins 17-18). Once library leadership agrees to revise policies, the next step is to engage teens, staff, and community members in policy review and development to maximize buy-in and ensure that the policies address the needs of diverse patron groups. This policy review and feedback process should be ongoing to allow for regular assessment and adjustment of patron codes of conduct as patron populations and needs shift over time. Throughout this process, libraries should ensure that their patron codes of conduct are written in plain language rather than legalese so that non-native English speakers, children, teens, and adults with limited literacy can easily understand the behavior expectations in public library spaces.

Another consideration is to work through the "why" of every rule or policy. Youth and teens are likely to ask "why" when a staff member redirects them, and having a logical and reasonable explanation for a rule increases the likelihood of compliance. An added benefit of getting down to the "why" behind policies is that doing so brings greater clarity. Take our earlier example in which "disrupting the normal flow of library operations or interfering with the use and enjoyment of the library by others" is prohibited ("Patron Code of Conduct"). This policy aims to ensure a pleasant library environment that operates smoothly for staff and patrons. In practice, staff could decide that anything from humming to laughter to eating a snack is "disrupting the normal flow" or "interfering with enjoyment," and explaining this "rule" to young people, in particular, is practically meaningless. All they take away from the interaction is "this library worker doesn't like me," and they may start to feel, as Gibson describes, that the library is not for them. Shauna Anderson, former Supervisor of Young Adult Services at Skokie

Public Library in Illinois, highlights the importance of balancing control and support in social discipline interactions. As Ella Ornstein and Peter H. Reid observed in case studies of teen-focused public libraries in Stockholm, Sweden, and Ithaca, New York:

> Treat teenagers with the same respect as any other library visitors. When issues do arise, discuss them with teens directly and offer options, rather than merely saying "no". [*sic*] Encourage teens to consider the ramifications of their actions, allowing them agency. Base rules on respectful sharing of common spaces, rather than being imposed from above by adults. Keep the focus on the behaviour, not the person, and make each day a clean slate. (Ornstein 465)

Intentionally creating clear, straightforward rules based on the desired library environment and articulating the reasoning for those rules could change the tone of behavior redirection interactions. The vague policy above could be teased into multiple simple statements of expected behavior in the library with logical reasoning to back them up. A policy in service to a pleasant library environment could be "Use appropriate noise levels." The explanation for this rule might be, "Excessive noise disrupts others. Use your indoor voice and keep the noise level reasonable. When using electronic devices, keep it on mute or use headphones. Headphones are available." Clear, accessible language in patron codes of conduct has the added advantage of facilitating staff consistency in enforcing rules.

Deciding to adopt youth-friendly policies and restorative justice practices is a great start. Still, that desire in an individual or a handful of librarians is insufficient to create meaningful and lasting change. According to librarian, professor, and long-time youth advocate Mary K. Chelton, "When the message comes from the top that inequitable service to teenagers is

unacceptable, things at the bottom may start to change. Administrative support is vital" (30). Library systems as a whole must commit. Staff training and education is essential. In order to successfully implement new restorative justice-based policies and practices, staff must get on the same page about youth and teen development and best practices for working with young patrons. Former director of the Redondo Beach Library in California, Susan Anderson, notes that "If you're friendly and chatting when things are going well, it will seem less like you are picking on [patrons when redirecting their behavior] because you have built up a good relationship" (Balzer). To this end, libraries should invest in restorative justice workshops for staff, bias training, and training in body language, tone, and de-escalation. Such training can help staff create a welcoming atmosphere and mitigate conflicts.

This internal work creates a foundation for building trust with youth and teen patrons, enabling libraries to be safer spaces for vulnerable patrons and foster meaningful engagement with them. "If library staff wants to build this kind of relationship with their teen patrons, the entirety of the library staff will need to respect and practice restorative justice" (Research 14). Research shows that staff attitudes significantly influence teens' library experiences, underscoring the need for administrative support for equitable teen services (Chelton, Ornstein). Teen spaces should be designed to accommodate both social and solitary needs, with staff trained to engage positively and act as neutral, supportive figures who can foster trust through informal conversations and consistent, respectful interactions (Chelton, Ornstein). Our youth and teen patrons deserve no less.

Acknowledging the need for youth-friendly policies and restorative justice practices in public libraries is crucial to fostering an inclusive environment for all patrons, particularly youth of color and other marginalized groups. The systemic inequities and biases outlined here

highlight how traditional patron codes of conduct often fail to account for the diverse realities of library users. Moving forward, it is essential for library professionals to actively reevaluate and transform these policies to ensure that they promote equity and understanding rather than exclusion and scrutiny.

Future research could examine the impact of redesigned patron codes of conduct on teen engagement in libraries. Possible studies might assess how these new policies affect participation rates in library programs among youth from diverse backgrounds. Additionally, investigations into the long-term effects of restorative justice practices within library settings could provide valuable insights into how such practices might build trust between library staff and patrons, ultimately enhancing the overall library experience.

On a professional practice level, libraries could benefit from ongoing training for staff on cultural competency and the systemic biases affecting their interactions with patrons. This training should include workshops that emphasize the importance of recognizing the unique needs of teenage library users and how to support them effectively. Libraries could also involve teens in creating and implementing policies that directly affect them, empowering young patrons and encouraging active participation in the library community.

By prioritizing research and practical applications that focus on equity and inclusion, public libraries can become even more welcoming spaces that honor the voices and contributions of all patrons.

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